

The Patriarchal Ideology of Barbie

Written By Omer Policker

The film *Barbie* (2023) directed by Greta Gerwig is a seemingly feminist work. It follows stereotypical Barbie through her journey of self-discovery in the real world. The film starts in Barbie land, a seemingly matriarchal utopia where women (the Barbies) are free to do anything they desire. It is a land where “all problems of feminism and equal rights have been solved” (3: 30-3: 45). However, once Barbie discovers the “real world” she realizes that the world is not equal and how the patriarchy runs the real world. Throughout the film, Barbie struggles with these stark differences between the two worlds until she decides to become a “real” woman and live in the real world. Despite its progressive facade, I believe that the film subtly reinforces traditional gender roles. This essay aims to dissect how the film *Barbie* perpetuates patriarchal ideologies through its narrative construction using theoretical frameworks from Laura Mulvey's "Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema" and Dr. Chanda Talha's "Deconstructing the Hero's Journey: Narrative Subversion in Feminist Fiction."

Firstly, Laura Mulvey's "Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema" provides a lens through which to analyze *Barbie* (2023) in terms of its feminist-coded narrative. Barbie, as a cultural icon synonymous with femininity and beauty, embodies this idealized version of womanhood. This iconography of women is prevalent in the Barbie film. "Thus the women as icon, displayed for the gaze and enjoyment of men, the active controllers of the look, always threatens to evoke the anxiety it originally signified." (Mulvey 811) This anxiety that Barbie feels throughout the film is a result of her newfound awareness of death but also the "diminishing" physical beauty of Barbie. Her physical changes seem more significant to Barbie than her philosophical discovery of death

due to it being explored more in the film through several scenes. For instance, Weird Barbie was played with too harshly in the real world and now is deemed weird due to her unattractiveness compared to the other Barbies. One of the Barbies states clearly how weird Barbie's unattractiveness affects her in Barbie land: "...she's faded to an eternity of making other Barbies perfect while falling more and more into disrepair herself." (19:00- 19:17)

First, her feet become flat and then she discovers that she began to develop cellulite. These changes are seen as repulsive by Barbie herself and the other Barbies. Additionally, Barbie only begins her journey into the real world after her body begins to change into something other than the norm. This fear of becoming unattractive is prevalent during a scene where weird Barbie wakes up Barbie after she returns from the real world. There is a non-diegetic horror sound as well as an insert shot of weird Barbie in the real world followed by weird Barbie in Barbieland.

(1:08:00) This presents the audience with the sheer horror of Barbie being unattractive. Following these frames, Barbie tells weird Barbie: "I'm like you now, ugly and unwanted." As soon as you remove her beauty, Barbie is no longer an icon. She is unwanted and this permeates into the real world.

Additionally, aside from the film placing importance on physical beauty, the lack of feminism in the film can also be represented in the work's narrative construction. Dr. Chanda Talha's exploration of narrative subversion in feminist fiction offers a counterpoint to the patriarchal narratives present in Barbie. Talha argues that feminist fiction disrupts traditional storytelling conventions, subverting the hero's journey archetype and challenging dominant power structures (Talha 18-19).

"Feminist fiction actively deconstructs the traditional Hero's Journey by reframing the hero archetype and offering alternative models of heroism. This subversion can manifest in various ways" (Talha 20)

One aspect of Talha's argument that becomes evident in the film is the lack of subversion in the portrayal of Barbie herself. Despite being positioned as a symbol of female empowerment and agency, Barbie's journey in the film aligns closely with the traditional hero's journey narrative structure. She starts in a familiar world (Barbieland), ventures into the unknown (the real world), faces various trials and challenges (Motel trying to capture her and the Kens taking over Barbie land), undergoes personal growth (starts to believe in herself), and ultimately returns transformed (decides to become a "real" woman in the real world). This linear trajectory, while empowering on the surface, ultimately reinforces a patriarchal notion of success and fulfillment that being a woman is to be a woman in a patriarchal society. Furthermore, Barbie's character arc primarily revolves around her physical appearance and societal acceptance, rather than challenging systemic injustices or dismantling oppressive structures. Her anxieties about her changing body and her struggle to conform to unrealistic beauty standards reflect a narrow conception of femininity defined by external validation and physical attractiveness. By centering Barbie's narrative on these superficial concerns, the film overlooks more substantive feminist issues and reinforces the patriarchal notion that a woman's worth is contingent upon her appearance.

However, there is a character that offers a semblance of subversion: Ken. Although Barbie is the titular character, Ken's storyline is more subversive to the hero's journey archetype. Ken's character in Barbie serves as a departure from traditional gender roles and expectations, providing a counterpoint to Barbie's narrative arc. Unlike Barbie, whose journey revolves primarily around physical appearance and societal acceptance, Ken's storyline challenges gender norms and expectations. Ken is depicted as a flawed and vulnerable character, subverting traditional notions of male strength specifically when singing the film's only musical number, "I'm Just Ken." This song delves into his insecurities and his desire for acceptance as he sings: "Doesn't seem to matter what I do, I'm always number two." (1: 26: 00) Despite this subversion, Talha is clear when she states that for the narrative subversion to be considered feminist you must "[showcase] strong and resourceful female protagonists who defy traditional gender norms and expectations." (Talha 20)

In conclusion, the film Barbie serves as a microcosm of patriarchal ideologies prevalent in mainstream cinema. Through its visual representation and narrative construction, Barbie perpetuates and reinforces traditional female gender roles while not doing so the same for men. However, by drawing upon theoretical frameworks from Laura Mulvey and Dr. Chanda Talha, we can uncover moments of resistance and subversion within Barbie's narrative for the Kens and less so for our titular female character.

Bibliography

Talha, Chanda. “Deconstructing the Hero’s Journey: Narrative Subversion in Feminist Fiction” .” *Lahore College for Women University, Lahore, 2023*.

Harvey, Laura. “Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema .” *Film: Psychology, Society and Ideology*, pp. 801–816.

Filmography

Gerwig, Greta, director. *Barbie*. Warner Bros., 2023.